Mary & Joseph

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CHOSEN: THE STORY BEFORE THE MANGER

SCENE 6 — MARY & JOSEPH

SCENE 6 — CONTINUOUS FROM SCENE 5

No blackout.

The rhythm that filled the workshop has disappeared with Joseph’s friends.

The unfinished table remains. Joseph still wears the satchel Mary made for him.

Mary and Joseph are alone.

JOSEPH
Mary...

Beat.

JOSEPH
What happened?

Mary remembers Shira’s instruction: Start with the truth.

MARY
I need to tell you something.

JOSEPH
All right.

MARY
I need you to listen.

JOSEPH
I’m listening.

MARY
All the way through.

That changes him slightly.

JOSEPH
Mary...

MARY
Please.

Joseph nods.

JOSEPH
All right.

Mary gathers herself.

MARY
I’m going to have a child.

SILENCE

Joseph looks at her. For a moment the sentence does not fit anywhere in his understanding.

JOSEPH
What?

MARY
I’m with child.

A tiny disbelieving breath escapes him.

JOSEPH
No.

MARY
Joseph—

JOSEPH
No, I mean—

He stops. Tries again.

JOSEPH
Are you certain?

MARY
Yes.

JOSEPH
Certain.

MARY
Yes.

Joseph’s first instinct is not accusation. It is protection.

JOSEPH
Did someone hurt you?

MARY
No.

JOSEPH
Did someone force you?

MARY
No.

JOSEPH
Are you protecting someone?

MARY
No.

Joseph searches her face.

JOSEPH
Then help me understand.

MARY
I’m trying.

JOSEPH
Then tell me what happened.

THE IMPOSSIBLE EXPLANATION

MARY
A messenger came to me.

JOSEPH
A messenger.

MARY
From God.

Joseph goes still.

JOSEPH
Mary.

MARY
His name was Gabriel.

JOSEPH
You’re saying an angel came to you.

MARY
Yes.

JOSEPH
And told you—

MARY
That I would have a son.

JOSEPH
And the father?

MARY
Joseph—

JOSEPH
What did he say?

MARY
That the child comes from God.

Joseph turns away. Not in disgust. He simply needs somewhere else to look.

JOSEPH
Listen to what you’re asking me to believe.

MARY
I have.

JOSEPH
No one else saw him?

MARY
No.

JOSEPH
He came to you alone.

MARY
Yes.

JOSEPH
And then he was gone.

MARY
Yes.

Joseph turns back.

JOSEPH
So all I have is your word.

MARY
Yes.

Beat.

MARY
I know.

JOSEPH
You know?

MARY
I know exactly what that means here.

The village outside the workshop remains ordinary and unchanged.

HE WANTS TO BELIEVE HER

MARY
You know me.

JOSEPH
That’s why this hurts.

Mary takes that in.

MARY
Then believe me.

JOSEPH
I want to.

Beat.

JOSEPH
I want to believe you.

MARY
Then do.

JOSEPH
Mary, I can’t make something make sense because I want it to.

MARY
It didn’t make sense to me either.

JOSEPH
But now it does?

MARY
No.

That surprises him.

MARY
Not all of it.

JOSEPH
Then how can you stand there and be so certain?

MARY
Because I know what happened to me.

JOSEPH
And I know what this looks like.

MARY
Those are not the same thing.

JOSEPH
They are from where I’m standing.

Mary steps closer.

MARY
Look at me.

Joseph does.

MARY
Have I ever given you a reason not to trust me?

JOSEPH
No.

MARY
Then trust me now.

Joseph wants to. That is visible before he answers.

JOSEPH
I don’t know how.

THE TABLE

Joseph turns away and finds the unfinished table in front of him.

His hand lands on it almost without thought.

JOSEPH
I was building this today.

MARY
I know.

JOSEPH
Six seats.

A small, broken breath that almost remembers the joke.

JOSEPH
Maybe eight.

MARY
Joseph—

JOSEPH
The window. Your garden. That ridiculous fence I’m apparently rebuilding for the rest of my life.

Mary’s eyes fill. These were happy things only hours ago.

JOSEPH
I could see it.

MARY
So could I.

JOSEPH
I knew where the door went. Where the table went. How much room we’d need.

He looks at her.

JOSEPH
I had a plan.

MARY
I know.

JOSEPH
And now I don’t know what any of it is.

MARY
Neither do I.

JOSEPH
But you’re asking me to live inside it anyway.

MARY
I’m asking you to believe that I’m telling you the truth.

THE BREAK

Joseph searches for one final explanation.

JOSEPH
Is there anything you haven’t told me?

MARY
No.

JOSEPH
Anything.

MARY
No.

JOSEPH
Something you’re afraid I won’t forgive?

MARY
Joseph, no.

JOSEPH
Because I would rather hear something terrible that I can understand than—

He cannot finish.

MARY
I don’t have an easier story to give you.

Joseph looks at her.

JOSEPH
I wish you did.

MARY
You think I betrayed you.

JOSEPH
I think something happened.

MARY
Something did happen.

JOSEPH
Something I understand.

MARY
That doesn’t make it true.

JOSEPH
And saying an angel came doesn’t make this make sense!

His first true emotional break. Silence immediately after it.

Joseph regrets the volume, but not the confusion.

MARY
I know.

JOSEPH
No, you believe.

MARY
Yes.

JOSEPH
And I don’t know how.

His eyes drop—not accusingly, but inevitably—to the reality of the child.

JOSEPH
The child...

Beat.

JOSEPH
It’s not mine.

SILENCE

MARY
No.

Joseph closes his eyes.

MARY
But that doesn’t mean—

JOSEPH
It’s not mine.

Silence. Joseph reaches toward the unfinished table, then stops. Mary waits for him to look at her. He cannot.

AFTERMATH

Mary and Joseph are now farther apart than when the scene began.

MARY
Joseph...

He cannot look at her yet.

MARY
What happens now?

JOSEPH
I don’t know.

MARY
Please don’t leave.

Joseph looks at her.

JOSEPH
What would you have me do?

MARY
Stay.

JOSEPH
And pretend I understand?

MARY
No.

JOSEPH
Pretend I believe something I don’t?

MARY
No.

JOSEPH
Then what?

MARY
Believe me.

Long beat.

JOSEPH
I want to.

Mary waits.

JOSEPH
I don’t know how.

JOSEPH’S CHOICE

The anger has burned away. What remains is grief.

JOSEPH
I won’t shame you.

Mary looks at him.

JOSEPH
I won’t make this public.

MARY
Joseph—

JOSEPH
Whatever people say about me, I won’t hand them something they can use against you.

MARY
Then don’t leave me.

That nearly undoes him.

JOSEPH
I can’t marry you.

SILENCE

MARY
You said whatever comes.

Joseph looks at her.

MARY
You said you’d walk with me.

JOSEPH
I know.

MARY
Then walk with me now.

Joseph cannot.

JOSEPH
When I said that...

He looks at the table.

JOSEPH
I thought I knew what “whatever comes” meant.

MARY
So did I.

That lands differently. Neither of them planned this.

JOSEPH
You still said yes.

MARY
Yes.

JOSEPH
And you believe.

MARY
Yes.

JOSEPH
I don’t.

There is the wall between them.

FINAL EXCHANGE

Joseph moves toward the exit.

He passes the unfinished table and stops. His hand rests on it once. He does not destroy it, overturn it, or remove anything from it.

MARY
Joseph.

He stops.

MARY
Please.

Beat.

MARY
Believe me.

Joseph remains facing away.

JOSEPH
I don’t know how.

Joseph exits.

Mary remains.

Do not have her collapse. She is devastated, but her yes still exists.

Her eyes find the unfinished table. She touches the edge Joseph had been working on.

A nearly imperceptible fragment of “Chosen” may return not triumphant, simply present.

Mary steadies herself.

The warm workshop environment remains. Nothing outside has changed.

END SCENE 6